

Developer: Rockstar Leeds and Rockstar North
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Score: 8.5/10

Grand Theft Auto: Chinatown Wars

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A fascinating aspect of the current generation of Nintendo platforms is not the hardware per se, but the way in which development studios around the world have used the features offered by the hardware. A recent example is *Grand Theft Auto: Chinatown Wars*. Not only have the devs managed to fit almost the entire Liberty City into the relatively miniscule capacity of a DS card, but they have expertly used the touch-screen and the microphone interface of the DS to great effect.

Chinatown Wars is presented through a rotatable camera and a perspective that is somewhere between a top-down and an isometric view. The top screen is where the game's action is displayed and the bottom screen functions as a PDA; for most of the game. True to the GTA tradition, the game offers several distractions to keep you entertained outside of the main story; distractions which double-up as a great way for earning some serious cash. These include all of your favourite gangster things—kidnapping, extortion, assassination, drug-dealing and of course, stealing cars. However,

what sets *Chinatown Wars* apart from other games is the more hands-on approach to the execution of said skills. Let's take one of the most common things that you'd do in a GTA game—steal cars. While we are used to the mechanic of just pushing a button next to a parked car and driving it away, this game will often test your thieving skills. Depending upon the type of car you are attempting to steal, the game will challenge you



to hot-wire the car before time runs out. This can range from simply turning a screwdriver into the ignition keyhole, to hacking a digital lock by using your PDA. Getting your hands on some Molotov cocktail is just as interesting—you need to buy some fuel from a petrol pump, fill up bottles with the liquid fire, and make a wick with a piece of cloth to complete the apparatus. These are only a couple of examples of how the developers

have used the input mechanism to introduce a level of depth and immersion to the game.

Chinatown Wars follows the exploits of a 25 year old spoilt son of a mob boss set out on a mission of revenge (his father's death) and delivery (a family sword). We all know that Liberty City is no city of angels; and predictably, she does not pull any punches for the protagonist of the game: No sooner than you land at the city's airport, you are greeted by a couple of wise guys that shoot you in the head, steal your family sword and throw you in the ocean to swim with the fishes. But since a dead protagonist doesn't make a GTA game (yet), you miraculously survive the Liberty City's welcome party. You are then given custody of a safe house and thrown in the thick of a power struggle: It appears that the death of your father and the aging of the incumbent don have led to a power vacuum, and as nature abhors that phenomenon, there are many takers eager to fill the void. Without giving too much of the plot away, the game's main storyline will give you an opportunity to work with many of these splinter groups to take control of Chinatown and subsequently investigate

a snitch in the 'family'. The game has some very interesting character archetypes — from an unhinged gangster that likes to pull out the heart of a man while he is still alive (and not in the romantic way), to a good-for-nothing narcissist with hopeless aspirations to becoming a mob boss. The banter between you and some of these colorful characters is the best we have seen in a GTA game — the script is wonderfully funny and infinitely entertaining.

One thing that really feels wrong with the game, at least at the onset, is the movement system. Maybe it is due to the unique (and arguably awkward) camera angle that the game employs, or perhaps we are just too used to the analog stick these days — but driving and player movement feels a bit odd during the early of hours of game play. You do get used to it, and quick, but there is a slight learning curve here. Furthermore, if you are among those who hate the way GTA lacks a mid-mission checkpoint, don't expect *Chinatown Wars* to be any different. Minor annoyances apart, this is a solid release on the Nintendo DS family of consoles. *GTA Chinatown Wars* deserves to be a part of every DS owner's game collection. **A**